



Foundational football: The Golden Baby Leagues is a long-term player development initiative designed to nurture a new generation of footballers — boys and girls — by introducing them to the game at the youngest age possible. AIFF MEDIA

called the Golden Baby Leagues (GBL), the matches are anything but competitive and are fairly low in number. For instance, an I-League or Indian Super League (ISL) team is mandated to play 21 matches in GBL to secure its license. At La Masia, the number of matches ranges from 40 to 55, and based on the players' ability, they are promoted.

"I was talking to a goalkeeper from Tajikistan during our latest trip there," says Priyansh Dubey, the goalkeeper of India's U-23 side.

"He told me that he started playing when he was six or seven. That's what makes them better. When I started playing (at the age of 12), they had already trained for four to five years."

The coronavirus pandemic only made things worse.

Over the last 10 years, the U-17, U-15 (started in 2015), and U-13 (started in 2017) leagues ran until 2019, when COVID-19 halted them temporarily.

The last two returned four years later, while the U-17 tournament

resumed a year prior. In a country that starts developing players six years late, that's a decade of football development lost.

Subroto Cup, India's oldest school football tournament, has also suffered. Madhyamgram High School, the record seven-time winner of the U-17 tournament, has failed to reach the finals since 1996. Once the launchpad for future India stars like Shyam Thapa, Bhaichung Bhutia and Bruno Coutinho, it is a shadow of its past — mired in controversies, with five teams disqualified last year for fielding overage players.

The scouts of ISL clubs, these days, prefer AIFF Junior (U-17) and sub-junior (U-15) tournaments over the Subroto Cup.

Inconsistent presence of academies

The presence of academies across all age groups has also been inconsistent. According to the AIFF, there are 94 accredited academies.

But the ones that have consistently participated in all four age-groups — U-13, U-15, U-18, and

U-21 — over the last 10 years and at the national level are just 10, a mere 10.6 per cent.

Clubs with consistent participation across all four age-groups (2015-2025)

- ✦ Reliance Foundation Young Champs (RFYC)
- ✦ Minerva Academy
- ✦ Sudeva Delhi FC
- ✦ Bhaichung Bhutia Football Schools (BBFS)
- ✦ Tata Football Academy (TFA, now called Jamshedpur FC Academy)
- ✦ Madras FC (formerly FC Madras)
- ✦ Bengaluru FC Academy
- ✦ Kerala Blasters FC Academy
- ✦ FC Goa Academy
- ✦ Chennaiyin FC Academy

There are two main reasons here. Firstly, the scheduling of age-group tournaments and the criteria have not remained uniform — an updated set of rules has been released before each season in the last decade.

Secondly, a lot of old academies — DSK Shivajians, JCT Mills, Mahindra FA, and the AIFF's own academy side, the Indian Arrows — have gone

« Only 13 of the 43 players called up to the national camp in the past year came from ISL club academies »